

Swamp Milkweed

Asclepias incarnata

Pink Milkweed · Rose Milkweed



QUALITIES

An upright clumping milkweed 3 to 4 feet tall, with narrow lance-shaped leaves and rounded clusters of small mauve-pink star-shaped flowers from July through August. Unlike Common Milkweed it does not spread by rhizomes — it forms a tidy clump that holds its place indefinitely. Spindle-shaped pods split in fall to release the iconic silk-tufted milkweed seeds.

CARE

Best in moist to wet soil; tolerates average garden soil if watered. Full sun. Hardy to USDA Zone 3. Plant from 1-gallon stock; like all milkweeds, slow to emerge in spring (mark the location). Long-lived once established; clumps remain in place rather than spreading. Deer-resistant. The flowers attract considerable pollinator traffic — site near a viewing area.

HISTORY

All North American milkweeds were used variously by Indigenous peoples — the silky seed floss as fiber (stuffed into life jackets during WWII when imported kapok was unavailable), the flower buds and very young shoots as cooked food, the latex sap as a wound dressing. Swamp milkweed specifically appears in Anishinaabe and Dakota wetland-edge plant lists. The common name is misleading — it grows fine in average garden soil so long as moisture is reliable.

REASON TO BE

Swamp milkweed is the second of three primary Monarch host plants. Where Butterfly Milkweed offers drought-tolerant prairie habitat and Common Milkweed offers spreading colonies, Swamp Milkweed offers a well-behaved clumping habit perfect for residential design. Female Monarchs lay eggs on swamp milkweed throughout July and August; the leaves are the exclusive food of the caterpillars. In a vegetated bioswale's moist slope, three Swamp Milkweed clumps make the swale a Monarch nursery.